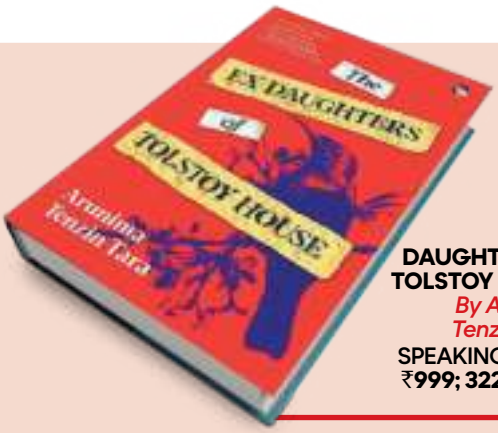


THE EX DAUGHTERS OF TOLSTOY HOUSE
By Arunima Tenzin Tara;
SPEAKING TIGER
₹999; 322 pages

BOOKS ▼

A BLOODY **AFFAIR**

For all its macabre overtones, *The Ex Daughters of Tolstoy House* is about WOMEN TACKLING PATRIARCHY

The central conceit of *The Ex Daughters of Tolstoy House*, Arunima Tenzin Tara's debut novel, is a compelling one—a family of women who have a supernatural ability to absorb blood into their bodies, and how this "gift" is exploited by their relatives to make them complicit in decades of violent crime and murder. As a metaphor, this works neatly for how women tend to take on the pain, invisible labour and guilt of their families, particularly on behalf of the men. Is the metaphor a little too on the nose? Maybe, because there's nothing particularly supernatural about the rest of the story. But I enjoyed the writer's bold choices, and her pushing of the boundaries of imaginative fiction.

The story is told from the perspective of two women: the mother, Meera, and the youngest daughter, Naina. Both are caught in the web of the husband and father, Ambarish, a character I wish had been fleshed out more. Ultimately, the story is about women, and their position in society and in families—and, to that end, it does not really do the strength of women justice. I was waiting for at least one of the younger women to rebel against the patriarch. Despite these quibbles, *The Ex Daughters of Tolstoy House* was a thought-provoking read, asking tough questions about the impact of generations of misogyny on women today, the choices they make, the lives they lead—and what they choose to pass on. ■

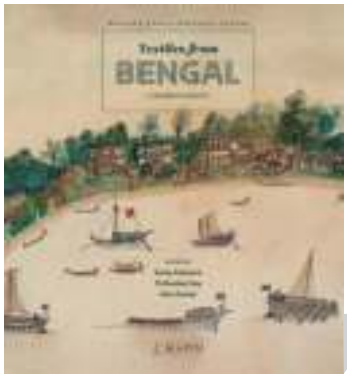
—Samyukta Bhowmick

BOOKS ▼

Into a Fabric **OF TIME**

***TEXTILES FROM BENGAL* IS A SEMINAL COLLECTION OF ESSAYS ABOUT THE STATE'S TEXTILE HERITAGE**

Lucknow may only be left with kebabs to claim as its own. Chikankari—synonymous with the city—may have originated in Murshidabad and travelled there, writes historian Rosie Lewellyn-Jones in her essay in *Textiles from Bengal: A Shared Legacy*. The editors of this book, Sonia Ashmore, Tirthankar Roy and Niaz Zaman, are unafraid to iron out a few creases in the fabric history of India. The coffee-table book aims to restore Bengal fabric's reputation rightfully as that which once 'clothed the world'. Written by historians and practitioners, and retrieved from archives and collections, this is a public history of cloth from Bengal that dominated the world.



TEXTILES FROM BENGAL
Edited by Sonia Ashmore, Tirthankar Roy and Niaz Zaman
MAPIN
₹4,950; 360 pages

Muslin might have been the original power dressing for the world. Marie Antoinette was clad in a muslin chemise from Bengal in her portrait by artist Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun in 1738. She didn't survive the revolution of 1789, but muslin did. Littered with such gems, the book encompasses the epic sweep of this fabric. But it goes beyond the gossamer Dhaka muslin that has come to define Bengal to introduce other wonders—like Balaposh, the winter shawl from Murshidabad "soft like wool, warm like a lap". The perfumed quilt was still made till the 1930s by artists Manohar Khalifa of Berhampore and his son Golap Dhunia of Jiaganj. If only for listing names of craftsmen, patrons, etc.—making the invisible visible—the book is essential reading.

The essays conjure up a complex story stitched together like kantha, cramming in the universe of memory, and of the lived experience of the textile. And especially of women who wove them—their stories, their dreams found in poetry and wrapped in the warp and weft of the cloth. So famed were they for their deftness that some were transported as slaves by the Dutch, another shocker the book delivers. The Iziko Slave Lodge in Cape Town has on display a baby cap and a fragment of lace knitted by Melati, a Bengali slave, with a caption "knitted by a slave of my grandmother worn by me in 1838". Lost in history, Melati never came home, but she can be remembered now. ■

—Mandira Nayar